

THE GARAMUT



A MESSAGE SENDER

Ps Barry's *Reflections on:* **PRAYER,** **PROCLAMATION and** **PERSONAL PROGRESS**

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EXPECTATIONS

We all have expectations for different things and that is good to be expecting God to bring about, those things that relate to our lives and service for Christ.

EXPECTATIONS

IN THIS REFLECTION WE WILL BE FOCUSING ON OUR EXPECTATIONS OF PEOPLE, INCLUDING LEADERS.

OUR TEXTS:

Matthew 3:1 In those days John the Baptist came, preaching in the Desert of Judea NIV

Matthew 3:4 John's clothes were made of camel's hair, and he had a leather belt around his waist. His food was locusts and wild honey. NIV

Matthew 11:7-9, 11, 16-19

7 As John's disciples were leaving, Jesus began to speak to the crowd about John: "What did you go out into the desert to see? A reed swayed by the wind? 8 If not, what did you go out to see? A man dressed in fine clothes? No, those who wear fine clothes are in kings' palaces. 9 Then what did you go out to see? A prophet? Yes, I tell you, and more than a prophet.

11 I tell you the truth: Among those born of women there has not risen anyone greater than John the Baptist; yet he who is least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he is!

16 "To what can I compare this generation? They are like children sitting in the market places and calling out to others: 17 'We played the flute for you, and you did not dance; we sang a dirge, and you did not mourn.' 18 For John came neither eating nor drinking, and they say, 'He has a demon.' 19 The Son of Man came eating and drinking, and they say, 'Here is a glutton and a drunkard, a friend of tax collectors and "sinners." 'But wisdom is proved right by her actions.'" NET

WHAT DID YOU GO OUT INTO THE DESERT TO SEE?

This Jesus asked this question to the crowd about John the Baptist and challenged them with that question.

- ♦ What was it that you were expecting to see?
- ♦ What were your expectations regarding John the Baptist?
- ♦ What kind of person did you have in mind when you reflected on John?

WHAT WERE YOU EXPECTING TO SEE IN JOHN?

- ♦ Those people that Jesus was speaking to would have been like most people who are curious, had their own expectations and attitudes about people and preachers particularly if it was a stranger and newcomer to their region.
- ♦ Also, Jesus' question refers to what was the criteria or basis used to determine or evaluate other peoples acceptance, status or validity.
- ♦ Did they have an attitude that was consistent with the teaching of the Jewish scriptures – God's Word?

BUT A SIMILAR QUESTION COULD BE ASKED OF US?

- ♦ **WHAT ARE OUR EXPECTATIONS OF OTHERS AND ON WHAT BASIS DO WE GIVE ENDORSEMENT OR ACCEPTANCE OF THOSE WHO ARE DIFFERENT TO OUR "NORMS"?**

Matthew 3:4 John's clothes were made of camel's hair and he had a leather belt around his waist. His food was locusts and wild honey. NIV

EXAMPLE:

What did you go out into the desert to see? A reed swayed by the wind?

1. John was not understood and wrongly judged. He was not easily swayed like a reed in the wind – he was definite, decisive, unbending and uncompromising in his message to everyone. Repent – change your ways – and live for God.

Matthew 3:1 In those days John the Baptist came, preaching in the Desert of Judea NIV

2. What would be our response to a person like John the Baptist – preaching in the wilderness (desert place) and not in the towns or cities), where his message could have had a greater audience?
 - ◆ That was something that raised questions, why there?
If not, what did you go out to see? A man dressed in fine clothes? No, those who wear fine clothes are in kings' palaces.
3. He was dressed strangely and very different to the norm.
 - ◆ People and preachers should not be judged according to their clothes- whatever kind they may be.
 - ◆ Was there misjudgement of John because of the austere clothes he wore? Did they expect to see someone to be in fine clothes acceptable to the acceptable current standards?
 - ◆ **What about you and I?**
 - ◆ What was the underlying lesson or message that Jesus was presenting when he said referring to when he said *those who wear fine clothes are in kings' palaces.*

Lessons from the Teacher

Those who wear fine clothes are in kings' palaces.

- ◆ Was Jesus saying that there are those people even prophets, leaders:
- ◆ Who focus more on their personal appearance rather than on the testimony of their inner person?
- ◆ Who placed more emphasis on Charisma instead of the Character?
- ◆ More on their preaching presentation rather than the nature of the substance of the message.
- ◆ Also was Jesus referring to people who place more emphasis on their status, position of authority in which they love to command and direct others instead of willingly, displaying a servant attitude by working alongside those who are actively engaged in the hands-on work.
- ◆ **Is this a valid and legitimate way** in which we should assess, evaluate a preacher or an ordinary person preaching the Gospel?
For John came neither eating nor drinking, and they say, 'He has a demon.'

4. John's unusual style, his clothes, his ascetic style of food all suggested to the crowd that he was 'strange' and possibly demon possessed, therefore he could not be a credible prophet or person to be preaching God's Word. In their estimation He was not sent by God.
*Then what did you go out to see? A prophet? Yes, I tell you, and more than a prophet.
I tell you the truth: Among those born of women there has not risen anyone greater than John the Baptist; yet he who is least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than he.*
 - ◆ There was nothing about John, his dress, his food, his lifestyle that revealed his greatness in the kingdom of God.
 - ◆ Everything about him spoke of humility, selflessness, and undeviating devotion to the mandate that he was chosen to perform in ushering in the Messiah, Christ Jesus.

WHAT CAN WE LEARN FROM THIS CHALLENGE THAT JESUS GAVE TO THE CROWD AND HIS DISCIPLES ALSO HEARING IT?

- ▼ What are we expecting to see in those who are preaching the word, e.g. a Prophet, Teacher & Leader?
- ▼ Are our expectations and assessment of others affected by their outward appearance – **their dress, looks, and differences to the status quo?**
- ▼ What are we expecting to find **in the life of a Christian?**
- ▼ What is it that we are really attracted to in people, **their charisma, influence, and dynastism? Or to something else, such as character?**
- ▼ What are our expectations for a local church? **What are we seeking to find and what if it is not up to our standard? Is our response a positive one of seeking to contribute to its growth?**
- ▼ What are you looking for in a partner in life, to marry? Are we attracted more to the **outward beauty / handsomeness etc or to the inner beauty / quality? Give thought to this factor?**
- ▼ **What do we go out to see,** when encountering another person, a Christian, a preacher, leaders etc?
 - What are our expectations of sinners and new people coming into our church?
 - What do we expect from those who are ethnically different in looks and dress etc; expect them assimilate into our culture?
 - Are our expectations of others fair or biased and are such persons capable of meeting those requirements?

AMEN - PS BARRY